web. It is the basic unit of an ecosystem, to maintain its stability in nature. Which is also called homeostasis.

Example: In a grazing food chain of a grass land, in the absence of a rabbit, a mouse may also eat food grains. The mouse in turn may be eaten directly by a hawk or by a snake and the snake may be directly eaten by hawks.

Hence, this interlocking pattern of food chains is the food web and the species of an ecosystem may remain balanced to each other by some sort of natural check.

Significance of food web

- Food web is constructed to describe species interaction called direct interaction.
- It can be used to illustrate indirect interactions among different species.
- It can be used to study bottom-up or top-down control of community structure.
- It can be used to reveal different patterns of energy transfer in terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems.

7.2.7 Ecological pyramids

Graphic representation of the trophic structure and function at successive trophic levels of an ecosystem is called **ecological pyramids**. The concept of ecological pyramids was introduced by **Charles Elton (1927)**. Thus they are also called as **Eltonian pyramids**.

There are three types: (1) pyramid of number (2) pyramid of biomass (3) pyramid of energy.

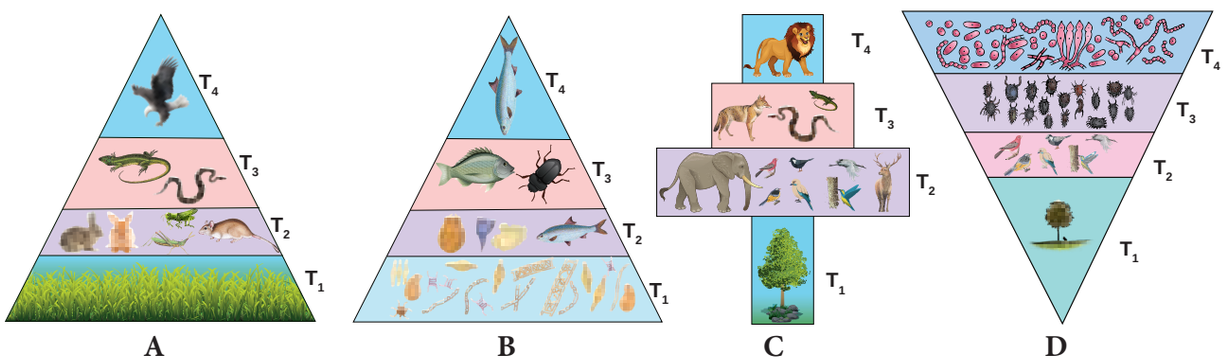
1. Pyramid of number

A graphical representation of the number of organisms present at each successive trophic level in an ecosystem is called **pyramids of number.** There are three different shapes of pyramids upright, spindle and inverted.

There is a gradual decrease in the number of organisms in each trophic level from producers to primary consumers and then to secondary consumers, and finally to tertiary consumers. Therefore, pyramids of number in **grassland** and **pond ecosystem** are always **upright**.

In a **forest ecosystem** the pyramid of number is somewhat different in shape, it is because the base (T_1) of the pyramid occupies large sized trees (Producer) which are lesser in number. Herbivores (T_2) (Fruit eating birds, elephant, deer) occupying second trophic level, are more in number than the producers. In final trophic level (T_4), tertiary consumers (lion) are lesser in number than the secondary consumer (T_3) (fox and snake). Therefore, the pyramid of number in forest ecosystem looks **spindle shaped**.

The pyramid of number in a **parasite ecosystem** is always **inverted**, because it starts with a single tree. Therefore there is



T_1 - Producers | T_2 - Herbivores | T_3 - Secondary consumers | T_4 - Tertiary consumers

Figure 7.8: Pyramids of numbers (individuals per unit area) in different types of ecosystems. **Upright**-A) Grassland ecosystem B) Pond ecosystem , **Spindle shaped** -C) Forest ecosystem, **Inverted**-D) Parasite ecosystem

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